

Peter Behrens and the Deutscher Werkbund

Widely regarded as the first industrial designer, and one of the most important architects of his time, Peter Behrens (1868–1940) was an influence on Mies van der Rohe, Le Corbusier, Walter Gropius and Adolf Meyer (1881–1929). A pioneer of corporate design for AEG (Germany's general electric company), he designed not only the factory and offices, but also the industrial products, stationery and company logo.

In 1907, seeking greater efficiency in the production of crafts, better design for industry and a more modern approach to architecture, Behrens helped establish the Deutscher Werkbund (German Work Federation), at the proposal of architect Hermann Muthesius (1861–1927). A state-sponsored fusion of art and industry, the Werkbund was indebted to the ideas of William Morris, as members (who included Gropius and Mies) sought to improve the design of everyday objects. Its motto was *Vom Sofakissen zum Stadtebau* ('from sofa cushions to urban construction').

